



KARSTEN MORAN FOR THE NEW YORK TIMES

6-2, 7-6, and 2:01 A.M.
Sofia Kenin beat Venus Williams in the wee hours of Monday, the latest finish for a first-round match in U.S. Open history. Page B9.

Russia Torments Kyiv With Drone Barrage ‘All Day, Every Day’

By **SIOBHÁN O’GRADY**
and **YURII SHYVALA**
KYIV, Ukraine — Russia has turned to a terrifying new tactic in its assaults on Ukraine, launching nonstop waves of armed drones in recent days into busy areas of the capital, Kyiv. The relentless attacks have left residents exhausted and on edge as air raid sirens have bellowed nearly constantly.
With Moscow sending drone af-

ter drone into Kyiv, including many powered with jet engines that help them fly so fast they are difficult to intercept, many in the capital have begun to accept that they may be facing a new phase of the war.
This period threatens to be more dangerous and unpredictable for Kyiv than any since the first weeks of Russia’s 2022 full-scale invasion. It comes as the city already faces increased danger from powerful Russian ballistic

Attacks Used to Come at Night, Affording a Bit of Respite
missiles as Moscow capitalizes on depleted Ukrainian air defenses.
While Russia has long conducted deadly drone attacks on Kyiv, the weapons have often come in overnight barrages and

have not tormented the city throughout the day. Residents long ago grew used to the menacing hum of slower-moving drones but now face the danger of the jet-powered models, which crash into a target before anyone nearby has a chance to run.
The waves of drones have arrived in Kyiv just as residents have been trying to enjoy the waning warm days of summer, craving some normalcy. On Saturday
Continued on Page A6

Designer Quits Met Exhibition After Backlash

By **VANESSA FRIEDMAN**
and **JACOB BERNSTEIN**
Facing an intense backlash, the influential fashion designer John Galliano has taken the unprecedented step of withdrawing from a planned exhibition in his honor at the Metropolitan Museum of Art.
“After much reflection and discussion with all those involved, I have decided, with great sadness, that it is best for the exhibition not to take place at this time,” Galliano wrote in a statement posted to his Instagram page.
He also expressed “profound and enduring” gratitude to the museum’s leadership, and acknowledged the pain his past words had caused.
“I do not want the debate surrounding me to place the Met in a difficult position or distract from the remarkable work of the Costume Institute,” he wrote. “I also recognize and respect that an exhibition honoring my work would be painful for some.”
In a statement on Monday, Max Hollein, the director of the Met, said, “Following thoughtful discussions with John Galliano, we have together decided not to proceed with the exhibition.”
The cancellation came at a time when a number of donors and political leaders were coming forward to express their opposition to the nine-month exhibition, which had been scheduled to begin with next year’s Met Gala.
In recent days, a furor mounted over the museum’s choice to honor Galliano, who was convicted of an antisemitic hate crime by a French court in 2011. He would
Continued on Page A17



ANA ELISA SOTELO FOR THE NEW YORK TIMES

Habitat at Risk
A once-thriving penguin colony in Peru is now threatened by a so-called Super El Niño. Page D8.

At the Tupac Trial, Old Rumors Shadow Combs

By **JULIA JACOBS**
and **ANUSHA BAYYA**
Duane Davis may be the man on trial in Las Vegas, charged with helping to arrange the 1996 drive-by shooting that killed Tupac Shakur. But during testimony, few days have passed without a mention of Sean Combs.
“P. Diddy, Sean Combs, Puffy — I don’t know what name he’s going by today,” one witness said on the trial’s second day of testimony, by way of identifying him for jurors.
Mr. Combs, who is in prison on prostitution-related convictions, was the record producer at the

Defendant Now Denies Rap Mogul Had Role
center of a 1990s bicoastal rap beef that has, for years, figured into theories about one of hip-hop’s most notorious killings.
He has long denied any involvement, but before the trial, in several settings, Mr. Davis accused Mr. Combs of ordering a hit on Mr. Shakur and his label boss, Marion Knight, known as Suge.
“He said he’d give us anything for those dudes’ head,” Mr. Davis

told the police in 2008, when he was under the threat of drug charges. That interview has become important evidence at Mr. Davis’s trial. He now disavows the remarks.
As the trial draws to a close this week, prosecutors, who lack key physical evidence, are relying heavily on the account that Mr. Davis gave not only to the police but also to podcast interviewers and in a memoir. Although he said someone else had pulled the trigger, he described himself as having played a central role in the killing.
Continued on Page A16

Hidden Gusher of Money Is Upending the Midterms

Super PACs Pour \$1 Billion in Anonymous Donations Into Battleground Races

By **SHANE GOLDMACHER** and **THEODORE SCHLEIFER**
In Michigan and Minnesota, tens of millions of untraceable dollars poured into recent Senate primaries trying to topple progressive Democratic candidates.
In Kansas, the torrent of secret money that boosted an obscure Democratic Senate candidate amounted to 100 times as much as what he had on hand in the final stretch of the primary.
And in Texas, Republicans exploited lax federal disclosure rules to spend secretly and try to nominate a weak Democratic candidate whose own party had denounced her as antisemitic.
All across America, the midterm elections are drowning in dark money.
A New York Times review of advertising data, campaign-finance filings and tax records revealed that about \$1 billion in anonymous money is sloshing through the political landscape in 2026, a staggering sum and yet almost certainly a low-end estimate, given how difficult this money is to trace.
Dark money is the term used by the campaign industry to describe political spending by groups that hide the names of their donors. The deluge is upending races from coast to coast, with billionaires, corporations and special interests hiding their agendas and involvement with relative ease.
It is impossible to know the full scale of this spending. The Times’s tally of the \$1 billion includes only what is publicly available, primarily television and digital ad purchases and donations to super PACs from nonprofit groups. These groups also fund political activity that is more difficult to track, such as direct mail, hiring influencers to boost favorable content or deploying door-knockers for causes that are not technically campaigns.
Yet the sum is more than “enough money to manipulate a lot of politicians and to put a lot of poison in the blood of the American political system,” said Nick Penniman, the chief executive of Issue One, a group that has sought to reduce the role of money in politics.
In August, one Wyoming group with a thin paper trail dating only to this spring, Choose Freedom Inc., sprang into action to reserve about \$22 million in ads to boost Republicans in two dozen battleground House and Senate races. The next day, another Republican-linked nonprofit rolled out a \$22 million campaign in 41 House districts. On Thursday, a nonprofit called Per Aspera Policy Inc. emerged from obscurity to place a \$3.7 million ad buy praising the Republican Senate nominee in Ohio.
All of it involved untraceable cash.
Secret money is not new. But the pervasiveness has reached industrial scale in 2026 — and serves as a preview of its coming prevalence in 2028. Nearly every major primary and battleground race this fall has been or will be shaped by secret funds. The anonymous expenditures are so big that, in some instances, they are outstripping the spending of campaigns themselves, making candidates seem like bystanders of their own elections. The trend is especially true in primaries.
In Texas, Senator John Cornyn was one of the cycle’s biggest ben-
Continued on Page A11

Supreme Court Puts Ballroom Back on Track

By **ANN E. MARIMOW**
WASHINGTON — A divided Supreme Court on Monday allowed construction to continue on President Trump’s luxury White House ballroom, which has been steadily rising to replace the East Wing the president tore down last fall.
In a 5-to-4 vote, the court said the preservationists who challenged the construction of the planned 90,000-square-foot ballroom did not have legal grounds known as standing to bring their lawsuit because they were not directly harmed by the project, estimated to cost \$400 million.
The majority emphasized that its order was not addressing the legality of the project and instead the question of who could sue to try to block it. But in practical terms, the order was a significant setback to the most serious legal challenge to the project, meaning the president seems likely to be able to complete construction. Halting the project now would probably require a fresh lawsuit from an individual or group with standing, such as Congress, which would be a nonstarter while Republicans control the House and Senate.
In an unusual lineup, Chief Justice John G. Roberts Jr. and the court’s three liberal justices dissented, saying the construction was “likely unlawful.”
The White House is “an iconic American building whose symbolism and history are wrapped up in its architecture,” the chief justice wrote in a lengthy dissent that quoted from Winston Churchill
Continued on Page A15



ALEX KENT/THE NEW YORK TIMES

The administration has reduced funds for “D.E.I.” paths.

Trump’s View Of Bike Lanes? They Veer Left.

By **RICHARD FAUSSET**
Four years ago, after President Joseph R. Biden Jr. fell from a bike, Donald J. Trump made a pledge to the American people.
“I will never, ever ride a bicycle,” he declared.
The joke landed because Mr. Trump is known to be more of a limo-and-golf-cart sort of guy. But more recently, his administration has begun acting on its deep aversion to cycling, revoking federal grants for what it calls “D.E.I. bike lanes.”
In a high-profile move this year, the administration even tried to remove a bike lane near the White House.
Sean Duffy, Mr. Trump’s transportation secretary, has argued that when bike lanes cut into space for cars and trucks, the result is more congestion, “longer travel times and wasted fuel.”
But Mr. Duffy and his colleagues have also deployed rhetoric
Continued on Page A15



INTERNATIONAL A4-9
Moving a Castle by Hand
In northern Japan, about 4,000 people used the ancient technology of hikiya to relocate Hirosaki Castle. PAGE A5

Surviving a Ferry Disaster
A vessel off the coast of Cyprus capsized in rough seas, leaving its passengers struggling to escape. PAGE A9

NATIONAL A10-19
Symbol of Old-Time Religion
For many, Dolly Parton represented an idealized style of faith centered in small rural congregations that prize community over ideology. PAGE A10

Grand Canyon’s Flooding Toll
Two were dead and more than a dozen unaccounted for after a flash flood near Bright Angel Creek. PAGE A16

SPORTS B7-10
Messi Ends Argentina Career
The soccer icon said he had retired from international action. He will still play for Inter Miami. PAGE B9



BUSINESS B1-6
Dwindling Oil Reserves
Governments are consuming their vast stockpiles as the struggle over the Strait of Hormuz continues. PAGE B1

Sky-High Drug Prices
A new cancer treatment costs nearly half a million dollars a year. What’s shocking is it’s not unusual. PAGE B1

SCIENCE TIMES D1-8
‘Magic Hands’ in the Lab
An A.I. model is trying to identify the hidden factors that make some research experiments succeed while others fail. To do so, the program is watching scientists’ every move. PAGE D1

Dementia’s Hidden Connection
For years, doctors were stumped about why a Pennsylvania man was having episodes of forgetting things and staring vacantly. It took experts in epilepsy to figure out the issue. PAGE D1

OPINION A22-23
Lydia Polgreen PAGE A22



ARTS C1-6
The Foo Fighters Formula
Dave Grohl, the group’s frontman, tells us how he packs decades of hit-making into a three-hour concert with something for fans of all ages. PAGE C1

